

Seven Types of Irrational Beliefs: Examples and Disputing Responses



Irrational Belief Type	Thought	Disputing Response
Arbitrary inference	"Since I did not practice 6 hours each day last week, I must be fooling myself to think I am trying."	This person is using a very high standard of duration of practice when judging himself or herself. The individual could say instead, "I wish I could find a way to practice more than I am currently doing." If the individual is practicing for hours every day, then almost no one but that person would consider that failing to try to improve. Perhaps it is time to create a new standard for judging the individual's efforts.
Overgeneralization	"I did not run very fast today; I am not going to get fast enough to compete well in the race next month."	Every runner varies in speed on some days compared to others—even the best in the world. Many factors determine speed on any given day, from attitude to nutrition to hydration to outdoor conditions, among many others. The seriousness of the desire to compete can be judged by many other things than just the speed of a run on a particular day.
Catastrophizing	"I did not win any tournaments last year; I cannot do this. I am past my prime."	Some people in any sport have likely won many times well past the person's age. If the client worked out harder or trained better, he or she could extend his or her prime for potentially many years. A better response is to create a plan to help the client do that, rather than for the client to make such exaggerated judgments about his or her ability.
Cognitive deficiency	"I know I was very sick this past week, but I cannot believe I played so poorly today."	Getting sick—especially very sick—can disrupt a person's muscle tone and lack of practice can negatively impact performance. This happens to most athletes at least some of the time. The individual should give himself or herself a break and more time to recover, rather than getting exasperated over failing to return to form in a few days after a serious illness. No one has superpowers outside of comic books.

Seven Types of Irrational Beliefs: Examples and Disputing Responses



Dichotomous reasoning	"I am either a winner or a loser."	Individuals can control their training and their efforts during a game, but they cannot control completely what their opponent does. If a person trains very hard and well and puts out a great effort, sometimes that individual may still lose on a given day. Over the long run, that approach can lead to a lot of winning. Viewing oneself as a loser just because the person lost one match can help make the individual more likely to lose.
Over-socialization	"I need liposuction to look good for the [figure skating] judges. You cannot be too thin."	The judges do like slim bodies, but a person can, indeed, look too thin. The judges will not like someone who is so thin that he or she cannot perform at the highest level. Other examples exist of competitors who succeeded with strength and skill, not just skin and bones.
Negative thinking	"I did not train on Tuesday this week. That is pathetic."	This thought ignores the positive: the fact that the individual did train on every other day this week. Just focusing on what one did not do and calling oneself names like "pathetic" will not motivate a person to work harder. An individual can motivate himself or herself by focusing on what he or she did well, too.